PENGUIN BOOKS

## *An Autobiography*

Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi was born in 1869 at Porbandar in western India. In 1888 he went to London to study law, qualifying in 1891, where he encountered liberal and Christian ideas, and the teachings of Tolstoy. Returning to India, he practised law there until 1893 when he left for South Africa. The Transvaal government's discriminatory policy led him to campaign for the rights of the Indian community using the method of passive resistance, which he called *Satyagraha* – truth force. Gandhi returned to India in 1915 and in 1925 he became President of the Indian National Congress. His first major clash with the British government came in 1919 over the Rowlatt Acts. He introduced the *hartal*, a strike during which the people devoted themselves to prayer and fasting. When this resulted in violence he left politics for a time and travelled throughout India to teach his main principles: Hindu–Muslim unity, the abolition of untouchability, and the promotion of hand-spinning. He wore a homespun cotton *dhoti* and shawl, which won the people's hearts, and he became known as Mahatma – the great soul. Gandhi was imprisoned many times, which, with his hunger strikes, badly affected his health. In 1934 he resigned as leader of the Congress, although he remained a powerful influence, and he became leader again for a short time in 1940–41. Gandhi continued to campaign against partition, until he realized its inevitability. However, on Independence Day, 15 August 1947, he refused to